

Lesson 37: “We Thank Thee, O God, for a Prophet” (See L37 [Study Guide](#))

Purpose: To help us recognize the need for our living prophet, understand his roles, and more faithfully obey his counsel.

“Profile of a Prophet,” President Hugh B. Brown, Conference Reports, [October 1967, 117-121](#); See also [speeches.byu.edu, October 04, 1955](#); Listen to “[Profile of a Prophet](#)” The link is above the BYU heading. (24:26)

1. Our need for a living prophet

Why do we need a living prophet today? †1. President Ezra Taft Benson

How have you been blessed because there is a living prophet on earth today?

2. The roles of our living prophet

The “members of the First Presidency and Quorum of the Twelve Apostles are all prophets, seers, and revelators. However, only the President of the Church is authorized to receive revelation for the entire Church and to exercise all the priesthood keys necessary to govern the Church.” (*Lesson Manual*)

Prophetic Roles as found in the Doctrine & Covenants:

A. D&C 1:38; 21:4-5; 43:2; 68:3-4. (The prophet speaks for the Lord and reveals the Lord’s will.)

What are some subjects on which we have received guidance from recent prophets?

B. D&C 20:21-26; Mosiah 13:33. (The prophet testifies of Jesus Christ and teaches the gospel.)

How has your testimony of the Savior been strengthened by the words of our living prophet?

C. D&C 21:1; Mosiah 8:13-18. (The prophet is a seer.)

“A seer is a prophet upon whom God bestows great power to know the past and the future. He can know of things that are not known or are hidden. He also can have the power to translate ancient records.” (*Lesson Manual*)

• D&C 101:43-54. Which commandment did the servants fail to obey? (D&C 101:46-50)

What could have been avoided if the servants had built the tower? (D&C 101:51-54)

“The President of the Church can see the enemy “while he [is] yet afar off” (D&C 101:54).

How does this apply to the attention we give the President of the Church?

What dangers have latter-day prophets seen and warned us about?

D. D&C 107:91-92. (The prophet presides over the Church.)

What blessings do we receive because the true Church is led by a prophet, chosen and guided by God?

How can we sustain the prophet in his role as President of the Church? (D&C 107:22)

3. Heeding the words of our living prophet

• D&C 21:4-6. “For his word ye shall receive, as if from mine own mouth, in all patience and faith.”

What does the Lord promise us if we obey the prophet’s counsel? †2. President Harold B. Lee

How can we learn of the prophet’s inspired counsel? †3. President Ezra Taft Benson

How can we better study and use the prophet’s general conference addresses individually and in our families?

How have you been blessed as you have followed the counsel of the prophet?

†4. Elder Bruce D. Porter

4. Latter-day prophets’ example of Christlike love

†5. Edwin F. Parry

Elder Spencer W. Kimball helping a mother and her children in an airport, *Our Heritage*, [page 131](#).

†6. Story about President B. Hinckley

What impresses you about the actions of these prophets?

What can we learn from their example?

5. The prophet will never lead us astray

†7. President Joseph F. Smith

†8. Alma P. Burton

†9. President Wilford Woodruff

Next Week: L38: “In Mine Own Way”; See L38 [Class Member Study Guide](#).

(You can download a free LDS Institute manual at: [Doctrine and Covenants Manual: Religion 324 and 325](#).) † •

†1. **President Ezra Taft Benson:** “The most important prophet, so far as we are concerned, is the one who is living in our day and age. This is the prophet who has today’s instructions from God to us today. God’s revelation to Adam did not instruct Noah how to build the ark. Every generation has need of the ancient scripture plus the current scripture from the living prophet. Therefore, the most crucial reading and pondering which you should do is of the latest inspired words from the Lord’s mouthpiece” (in Conference Report, Korea Area Conference 1975, 52).

†2. **President Harold B. Lee:** “The only safety we have as members of this church is to do exactly what the Lord said to the Church in that day when the Church was organized [see D&C 21:4–5]. ... There will be some things that take patience and faith. You may not like what comes from the authority of the Church. It may contradict your political views. It may contradict your social views. It may interfere with some of your social life. But if you listen to these things, as if from the mouth of the Lord himself, with patience and faith, the promise is that ‘the gates of hell shall not prevail against you’ [D&C 21:6]” (in Conference Report, [Oct. 1970, 152](#)).

†3. **President Ezra Taft Benson:** “For the next six months, your conference edition of the Ensign should stand next to your standard works and be referred to frequently” (“[Come unto Christ, and Be Perfected in Him](#),” *Ensign*, May 1988, 84).

†4. **Elder Bruce D. Porter:** “When my wife and I were a young married couple, we lived in the Boston area, where I attended school. Another young couple moved into our ward shortly after we did. They were converts of about two years. ... I accepted the calling to be their home teacher. I looked forward to helping strengthen their testimonies of the gospel.

“My companion and I arrived at their modest apartment one evening to home teach them. They had just completed a home evening with their little baby. I made a mental note that it would be a good idea for my wife and I to start holding home evenings so ... when a child arrived we would already have the habit. They then eagerly showed us their Book of Remembrance in which they had collected many names of ancestors from both sides of their family. I remembered that it had been a long time since I had looked at my Book of Remembrance.

“After our lesson they took us out to the screened back porch where were stacked ice cream buckets filled with wheat, sugar, flour, and other food—a complete year’s supply of food. I had supposed, somehow, that as students that counsel didn’t apply to

us! By now I was feeling very humble. I had come to teach them, but they were teaching me in every point. As we left their little apartment I noticed a picture of the temple hanging near their door. I remembered that President Spencer W. Kimball said that every Latter-day Saint family should have a picture of the temple prominently displayed in their home, and I remembered that we didn’t have one. ...

“I went home, filled with a spirit of repentance, and found a small picture of the Swiss Temple in a mission brochure. I cut it out and taped it on our wall. Since that time we have always had a picture of the temple in our home. Every time I look at it, it reminds me of a young convert couple who taught us what it meant to ‘follow the prophet’” (address given in the Bountiful Mueller Park Stake conference, 17 Jan. 1999).

†5. **Edwin F. Parry:** “John Lyman Smith and his family came to Nauvoo when it was first being settled by the Saints. The only place the family could find to live at first was a stable made of logs. Everyone in the family except the mother soon came down with fevers as a result of living in the swampy area. John Lyman Smith said of the experience:

“‘The Prophet Joseph Smith and his brother Hyrum visited us and administered to all of us, father being delirious from the effects of the fever. Their words comforted us greatly, as they said in the name of the Lord ‘you all shall be well again.’ Upon leaving the hovel, Joseph placed his slippers upon my father’s feet and sprang upon his horse from the doorway and rode home barefoot. The next day Joseph removed father to his own house and nursed him until he recovered’” (quoted in *Stories about Joseph Smith the Prophet: A Collection of Incidents Related by Friends Who Knew Him*, comp. Edwin F. Parry [1934], 33–34).

Recommended reading:

1. President Hugh B. Brown, “Profile of a Prophet,” Conference Reports, [October 1967, 117-121](#).
2. President Gordon B. Hinckley, “[We Thank Thee, O God, for a Prophet](#),” General Conference, Oct. 1973. (Listen to it, as you read it. I was moved to tears.)
3. President Ezra Taft Benson, “[Fourteen Fundamentals in Following the Prophet](#),” February 26, 1980, [speeches.byu.edu](#).
4. Alma P. Burton, “[Follow the Brethren](#),” *Ensign*, Oct. 1972.

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†6. Story about President Gordon B. Hinckley: “In 1998 a devastating hurricane caused great destruction in Central America. The Church sent large amounts of relief food and supplies. President Gordon B. Hinckley felt that he should go to Honduras and Nicaragua to meet with and encourage the people there. Later in a Christmas devotional, President Hinckley spoke of a two-year-old girl he met on this trip who had been orphaned in the disaster. Her mother had died a few months before the hurricane, and when the hurricane hit, the father piled the furniture in his house to avoid the rising water.

“President Hinckley related that the father ‘took a little mattress and placed it at the top and laid [his daughter] on it. In his frantic and desperate effort he suffered a stroke and died. ... No one knew anything of her, until a young man, two days later, happened to look up in that abandoned house and saw her still alive. He tenderly brought her down and delivered her to the bishop and the bishop’s wife. It was there that we saw her....

“I would hope that at this Christmas season, when there will be no gift-giving among these devastated people, this small orphan girl might receive perhaps a little taste of candy, something sweet and delicious. I must see that that happens.

“God bless the people everywhere ... that their hearts may be opened and their hands extended to help the needy” (*Church News*, 12 Dec. 1998, 4).

†7. President Joseph F. Smith: “If [the President of the Church] should become unfaithful, God would remove him out of his place. I testify in the name of Israel’s God that he will not suffer the head of the Church, whom he has chosen to stand at the head, to transgress his laws and apostatize; the moment he should take a course that would in time lead to it, God would take him away. Why? Because to suffer a wicked man to occupy that position would be to allow, as it were, the fountain to become corrupted, which is something he will never permit” (*Gospel Doctrine*, 5th ed. [1939], 44–45).

†8. Alma P. Burton: “President Wilford Woodruff once related that in a meeting held in Kirtland, Ohio, in the early days of the Church, one of the leaders addressed a group of the brethren on the subject of the living oracles of God. The brother who addressed the group set forth his beliefs in these words:

“You have got the word of God before you here in the Bible, Book of Mormon, and Doctrine and Covenants; you have the written word of God, and you who give revelations should give revelations according to those books, as what is written in those books is the word of God. We should confine ourselves to them.”

“When this speaker had finished his remarks, the Prophet Joseph Smith turned to President Brigham Young and said:

“‘Brother Brigham I want you to take the stand and tell us your views with regard to the living oracles and the written word of God.’ Brother Brigham took the stand, and he took the Bible, and laid it down; he took the Book of Mormon, and laid it down; and he took the Book of Doctrine and Covenants, and laid it down before him, and he said: ‘There is the written word of God to us, concerning the work of God from the beginning of the world, almost, to our day. And now,’ said he, ‘... those books do not convey the word of God direct to us now, as do the words of a Prophet or a man bearing the Holy Priesthood in our day and generation. ...’ When he was through, Brother Joseph said to the congregation, ‘Brother Brigham has told you the word of the Lord, and he has told you the truth.’” (“[Follow the Brethren](#),” *Ensign*, Oct. 1972)

†9. President Wilford Woodruff: “We may take the Bible, the Book of Mormon and Doctrine and Covenants, and we may read them through, and every other revelation that has been given to us, and they would scarcely be sufficient to guide us twenty-four hours. We have only an outline of our duties written; we are to be guided by the living oracles.” (*Journal of Discourses*, [vol. 9, p. 324, on April 8, 1862](#))

Recommended media:

1. Video: [Watchman on the Tower](#) (4:17).
2. Video: [We Need Living Prophets](#) (2:45).
3. Video: [God’s Words Never Cease](#) (2:54).
4. Mormon Tabernacle Choir: [We Thank Thee, O God, for a Prophet](#) (October 2013, 4:08)

Further recommended reading:

1. [Ted L. Gibbons](#), “D&C Lesson 37: We Thank Thee, O God, for a Prophet,” Sep. 06, 2013, [ldsiving.com](#).
2. [Nancy Jensen](#), “D&C #37 ‘We Thank Thee, O God, For a Prophet,’” Sep. 15, 2013, LDS Gospel Doctrine Plus.
3. Lynn England and W. Keith Warner, “[President of the Church](#),” *Encyclopedia of Mormonism*.

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